

World in Brief: Starmer out and Burnham on the way in; Vance says Iran will host nuclear inspectors



Photograph: Shutterstock

Andy Burnham was sworn in as an MP. The [former mayor of Greater Manchester](#) is the most probable successor to **Sir Keir Starmer** as leader of Britain's Labour Party and thus prime minister. Sir Keir said he would resign earlier on Monday, having lost the support of his party. Nominations for his replacement will open on July 9th, but it looks set to be a coronation.

Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf, **Iran's** lead negotiator, arrived in Oman for talks on the **Strait of Hormuz**. Meanwhile, J.D. Vance said **Iran** had agreed to host UN nuclear weapons inspectors. Speaking in Switzerland after [preliminary peace talks](#), America's vice-president also outlined a plan to unfreeze Iranian assets, which he said would have to be spent on American goods like soy and wheat.

America's Treasury authorised the production, delivery and sale of **Iranian oil** and petrochemicals for 60 days. The temporary licence, which excludes Cuba, North Korea, Donbas, Crimea and Novorossiia, allows oil to be imported into America for the first time since the Iranian revolution in 1979. Meanwhile the [price of](#)

[Brent crude](#), the global benchmark, fell to \$78 a barrel—its lowest level since March.

Alan Greenspan, who served as chairman of the Federal Reserve between 1987 and 2006, under four American presidents, died aged 100. [Mr Greenspan](#) oversaw one of America's longest periods of economic expansion. But he will be remembered for his laissez-faire approach to financial regulation, which some see as responsible for the housing bubble that led to the financial crisis in 2008.

Sir Jeffrey Donaldson, [the former leader](#) of Northern Ireland's Democratic Unionist Party, was found guilty of 18 counts of child sex abuse, including rape. The jury concluded that his wife aided his crimes, but she was deemed mentally incapable of facing trial and cannot be jailed. Sir Jeffrey will be sentenced in September. The judge said his time in prison would be "lengthy".

Qatar confirmed that 13 people were killed and 66 injured by an explosion at a gas facility inside the country's Ras Laffan complex on Sunday. QatarEnergy, its state-owned operator, said the incident was an accident and not "hostile in nature". Ras Laffan's liquefied natural gas facilities, which were [damaged by an Iranian drone strike](#) in March, were not affected.

Lionel Messi became the top men's **World Cup** scorer of all time, scoring a record 17th goal for Argentina in a match against Austria—and an 18th during the game's final minutes. Mr Messi has played in six consecutive [World Cups](#). With his goals in Texas on Monday he overtook Miroslav Klose, a German player with whom he was previously tied for the record.

Figure of the day: 3.3%, the percentage of straight American couples in which the woman is taller than the man, according to our analysis of survey data. [Read why](#) short men continue to struggle in the dating market.

Israel out in the cold



Photograph: Getty Images

An official date has yet to be set for Israel's parliamentary election, but political insiders expect it to be October 20th. With four months to go, Binyamin Netanyahu is starting his re-election campaign at a low point.

Donald Trump's decision to sign a [memorandum of understanding with Iran](#) has damaged the prime minister's main selling points to the Israeli electorate. For decades he has made Israel's confrontation with Iran central to his agenda. Since 2016, when Mr Trump was first elected, he has also presented himself as having a unique partnership with America's president. Israel and America's joint decision to launch war against Iran in February seemed to prove the point.

Now this image looks tarnished. Mr Trump and his vice-president, J.D. Vance, have fiercely criticised Israel for not abiding by a [ceasefire in Lebanon](#). As America and Iran begin talks over the next stage of their deal, Israel can only look on in frustration.

Ukraine's strengths and vulnerabilities



Photograph: Reuters

The sight of columns of black smoke rising from an oil refinery in Moscow last week was testimony to the growing impact of [Ukraine's strike campaign](#). It showed how successfully the Ukrainians have depleted Russia's air defences even around the capital. Over the weekend officials in Russian-occupied Crimea also halted the sale of fuel at petrol stations because of Ukrainian drone attacks. On the ground, meanwhile, the picture is one of Russian pressure but minimal, if any, gains. One military analyst, Mick Ryan, describes the frontline as "a deep grey zone where control of ground changes rapidly and is continually contested".

Still, Russia can terrorise Ukrainian cities through its own aerial campaign. Ukraine's president, Volodymyr Zelensky, warned on Saturday of an impending "new massive strike". Its stockpile of Patriot interceptors is almost empty, leaving the country increasingly vulnerable to Russian ballistic-missile attacks.



A change of pace at China's central bank



Photograph: Alamy

China tends to do things in a rush. One exception is monetary policy. Unlike most central banks, which set an overnight interest rate, the People's Bank of China sets a rate for a leisurely seven days. It has also allowed market rates to drift quite far from this benchmark: as much as 0.5 percentage points above or 0.2 points below.

Last week, however, the central bank said it would henceforth run a tighter ship. The “corridor” within which rates can drift will narrow from 0.7 percentage points to 0.5. The bank will also pay more attention to overnight rates, a step toward shortening its policy rate. Its decisions filter through to longer-term commercial rates, like the loan-prime rate, a benchmark for mortgages, which was left unchanged on Monday. [China](#) is modernising its central banking. A week is a long time in politics, and in monetary policy, too.

The downside of Canada's oil windfall



Photograph: Reuters

On Monday Canada's inflation figures for May will show to what degree high energy costs have pumped up consumer prices. The Canadian economy has been behaving like a passenger jet flying on one engine. The bump in oil prices caused by the war in Iran has benefited oil-producing provinces in western Canada. But tepid business investment linked to Donald Trump's tariffs on steel, aluminium and Canadian-built cars has hobbled the eastern provinces and kept the economy from gaining altitude.

Economists expect Canada's annual inflation rate was around 3% last month, at the top of the Bank of Canada's target range of 1-3%. Still, the central bank is also weighing the risk that the economy could slow further, particularly amid uncertainty over the future of [Canada's trade pact with America and Mexico](#). Last week it decided to hold interest rates at 2.25%, but said that monetary policy would need to be "nimble".

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: Those born between July 23 and August 22 are generally associated with which Zodiac sign?

Life did not intend to make us perfect. Whoever is perfect belongs in a museum.

Erich Maria Remarque